The Intelligent Design of Jenny Chow

By Rolin Jones

JENNIFER: Okay, so here we go . . . My name is Jennifer Marcus and one of the first things you're going to have to get used to is that I'm better than you. Wait I'm not being conceited, not really, you know, there's a lot of baggage that come with it. I'm pretty much a complete disappointment to both my parents. My mother's totally fed up with me. You see I have this thing called Obsessive-Compulsive Disorder. And it puts a lot of pressure on everyone in the house. It started in high school with some mild Tourette's. Just little stuff like, "Alrighyeah" or like "Okaywhatever" and no one noticed, you now. See, what OCD really means is that it takes me a lot of time to what most regular people can do in a minutes. And so the truth is, I have a hard time getting out of the house. What I mean is it's not just OCD anymore. It's maybe, like kinda, sorta . . . agoraphobia. Though it's not like I'm afraid to leave my house, that's not it. It's just a lot easier to stay inside where you can manage the germs and the noise and . . . if you've got some Ethernet cable, it's more like a cathedral than a house. The world, the whole world, you know, can pass right through your house. You don't have to even move. And it's beautiful, you know.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

Intro is spoken by the actress playing Adele until the last line, which is voiced together.

International adoption is by its nature an emotional journey, one that traverses the highs of creating a family and the inevitable lows born of jarring change. The road can be rough, both for the parents who often must deal with children with post-traumatic behavioral issues, and for kids who suddenly find themselves immersed in a new family and a strange culture.

This scene shows just such a family in turmoil. Jennifer, Adele's 18 year old daughter, adopted from China as an infant, is struggling with many issues; and Adele, insecure in her own position as "Mom" is struggling as well.

The Intelligent Design of Jenny Chow by Rolin Jones.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JENNIFER: *(SHE walks to the kitchen where ADELE is sitting, waiting, staring off into space, with a drink in her hand. SHE'S plowed.)* Oh.

ADELE: Hi.

JENNIFER: How was your trip?

ADELE: It was what it was.

JENNIFER: How was the acquisition?

ADELE: It happened. How come the garbage is still in the back, Jennifer?

JENNIFER: I forgot.

ADELE: What are we going to do with you, Jennifer?

JENNIFER: Welcome back, Mom. *(JENNIFER turns to leave.)*

ADELE: No. We're not finished.

JENNIFER: I'm tired.

ADELE: You're tired? No, you're not. You haven't been in fourteen-hour negotiations. Your secretary didn't forget to book you a room. You weren't rerouted three times this week. You didn't have to fire a lifetime employee, someone who's been with the company for twenry-eight years and barely makes enough to support his family. And you sure as hell didn't do it the same day the company picked up a two-thousand-dollar dinner. You're not tired, Jennifer. I'm tired.

JENNIFER: Okay. Then you should probably go to bed.

ADELE: No. I can't go to bed because my house is in disarray.

JENNIFER: What are you talking about?

ADELE: Take out the garbage. Do some dishes. Am I asking too much?

JENNIFER: I've been busy.

ADELE: Online. With your little cyberboyfriend ...

JENNIFER: You're drunk.

ADELE: ... Hello, cyberfriend. Can you find my mommy for me?

JENNIFER: Whatever.

ADELE: You think you're a princess ....

JENNIFER: You're totally plowed.

ADELE: ... A little Chinese princess? Isn't that what you think? Think your father and I stole you away from the queen? We're keeping you from your life as the emperor's daughter, huh?

JENNIFER: Shut up.

ADELE: What happened to you, Jennifer?

JENNIFER: You happened to me.

ADELE: Oh, is that right? I ruined your life? Me, who got on a plane, brought you back here. Put you in this house, put you into every accelerated program, every activiry. Fed your brain.

JENNIFER: I didn't ask for this house and I hated those classes.

ADELE: *(Reliving it.)* Ms. Hartwick, Mr. Marcus. Your little girl's a genius. What do you do, Jennifer?

JENNIFER: I don't care.

ADELE: You can't even imagine. Of course you can't, you weren't there. You were out on the playground. They give you a handbook.

JENNIFER: Oh, of course, the handbook ...

ADELE: Page one. Never tell them they're a genius.

JENNIFER: Never tell them you're good at anything ....

ADELE: Page two ...

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JENNIFER: How to deprive your child of joy and wonder while preparing her for a life of infinite servitude.

ADELE: She abandoned you ...

JENNIFER: Yeah? Then how come her name is on the birth certificate?

(The following dialogue overlaps until "GO!')

ADELE: ... left you on a doorstep ...

JENNIFER: How would they know that?

ADELE: ... and you want to *replace* me?

JENNIFER: This isn't about the garbage cans.

ADELE: You don't know what we've done for you.

JENNIFER: It's maybe I'll like her more. Isn't that it?

ADELE: You had so much potential. ...

JENNIFER: She loved me.

ADELE: A brilliant child. And I am ...

JENNIFER: And I'm going to find her.

ADELE: ... totally mystified by what has happened to you.

JENNIFER: Did you hear me? I'm getting out of here.

ADELE: Go. GO! *(JENNIFER heads for the front door.)*

JENNIFER: I'm going to find her. I want to meet my real mother.

ADELE: Yeah, and how are you going to do that?

JENNIFER: I'll fly.

ADELE: You got a passport?

JENNIFER: I'll get one.

ADELE: You got a travel visa?

JENNIFER: I'll contact the embassy. *(JENNIFER opens the front door.)*

ADELE: Yeah? And how are you going to get to the airport, huh? How are you going to get out the front door? *(JENNIFER stands in the door frame. SHE is breathing*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

hard.) They make names up, Jennifer. They do that, you know? They just fill in the blank. And that's the truth. There's probably a thousand birth certificates with her name on it. And that silly scarf you wear around ... probably the nurse's. The truth? That woman abandoned you. And your father and I took two years filling out the paperwork, getting signatures and mortgaging our lives into the stratosphere so we could get on a plane, to **!!** scary country where we knew *no one!* So we could save your life. *(JENNIFER keeps putting one foot out the door and then bringing it back in.)* We would never give up on you. We love you. And that is why I push you. That is why I won't let you accept this as your life. And I'll be damned if I'm going to let you throw it away, let you spend it with flunkies like Todd, people with not an ounce of ambition. *(JENNIFER is trying not to lose it in front of ADELE, who slowly walks toward her.)* Listen to me. Listen. My daughter is brilliant. My daughter is an exceptional young woman. And I am not going to let her waste away. *(ADELE tries to hug JENNIFER from behind).*

JENNIFER: *(Freaking out.)* Don't you touch me! Don't you ever fucking touch me again! *(SHE runs away from ADELE, back to the kitchen, shaking her hands frantically.)*

ADELE: I live in the real world, Jennifer. I'm real. And in the real world, women get screwed out there and if you're not prepared they will squash you. So blame me, lash out at me for your condition, but don't-

JENNIFER: I'm going to find her. I'm going to China.

ADELE: Sure, go to China when you can't even take out the garbage. Keep dreaming.

JENNIFER: I'm going there. You watch me. *(SHE runs to her room, ADELE shuts the front door.)*

ADELE: *(Loud.)* The only way you're going to get to China is if this house grows wings. *(ADELE exits, JENNIFER sits down at her computer, typing feverishly.)* *(Offstage, loud.)* I'm real. This house is real, Jennifer. And you can hide in

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

your room and log on if you want to. But that's not real! That's a dream! *(We hear a door slam.)*

JENNIFER: Dear Dr. Yakunin. It's me, Jennifer Marcus. I know you haven't heard from me in a while, but I need to talk to you immediately. You're the only person I know who'll understand. Find me, please. I need your help. *(SHE stops typing.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rolin Jones
ISBN: 978-0822220718
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2006

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY